

Chapter 17

Cultural Globalization

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THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN GLOBALIZATION AND CULTURE

It may seem a rather obvious point to begin with, but to understand the meaning and character of ‘cultural globalization’ we first have to understand some defining features of the two constituent terms. So let’s begin with globalization.

Virtually every serious scholar today would accept the broad general proposition that globalization is a *multidimensional* process, taking place simultaneously within the spheres of the economy, of politics, of technological developments – particularly media and communications technologies – of environmental change and of culture. One simple way of defining globalization, without giving precedence or causal primacy to any one of these dimensions, is to say that it is a complex, accelerating, integrating process of *global connectivity*. Understood in this rather abstract, general way, globalization refers to the rapidly developing and ever-densening network of interconnections and interdependencies that characterize material, social, economic and cultural life in the modern world. At its most basic, globalization is quite simply a description of these networks and of their implications: of the ‘flows’ around them – and across international boundaries – of virtually everything that characterizes modern life: flows of capital, commodities, people, knowledge, information and ideas, crime, pollution, diseases, fashions, beliefs, images and so forth.

This increasing connectivity is, in many ways, an obvious aspect of our lives. It is something we can all of us – at least if we live in the more developed parts of the world – recognize in everyday routine actions and experiences. Connectivity pretty much defines our use of communications technologies – mobile phones, computers, e-mail, the Internet – but it is also characteristic of the urban environments most of us inhabit and it increasingly influences the way we earn our living, the styles of food we eat, the music, cinema and television that forms our entertainment, and our experience of mobility and travel. It also forms the backdrop to all manner of social and material anxieties and perplexities that characterize everyday modern life: from the shadow cast by terrorist attacks to worries over global warming, influenza

pandemics or how fluctuations in the global economy are likely to affect our job security, our taxes or the interest payments on our home loans. In all these ways, it is quite clear that we are living in a much more globally connected world today than even 20 years ago, and in longer historical terms the level of global interdependence is without precedent.

So understanding globalization as a generalized process of increasing connectedness helps us to keep in mind the multidimensional *complexity* of the process. But there nonetheless remain a good many tacit assumptions as to the relative importance of each of these dimensions. And it is clear that chief amongst these assumptions is that it is the *economic* sphere, the institution of the global capitalist market, that is the crucial element, the *sine qua non* of global connectivity. This is the dimension that dominates the imagination and the language of corporate business, of politicians and of anti-globalization activists alike; it is the easy shorthand of the media discourse which forms most ordinary people's immediate understanding of what globalization is all about.

There is no escaping the global dominance of the capitalist system and there is little to be gained by cultural analysts from understating its huge significance. But, having said this, we must resist the temptation to attribute it with causal primacy in the globalization process. There are several reasons for this, but here I will only mention two. First, because we are not dealing with straightforward empirical judgments about what specific practices drive everything else, but also with questions of the constitution of analytical categories: to what extent are economic practices also, intrinsically, *cultural* ones? Plausible answers to this question range between 'somewhat' and 'entirely'. What is *not* plausible – despite the constant rhetorical gestures of politicians towards the 'hard economic realities' – is the assumption that the realm of the economic is that of a machine-like system operating independent of the wishes, desires and aspirations of human agents, and thus entirely outside of the influence of culture. So the first reason to resist the temptation to economic reductionism is that it operates on an unrealistically narrow conception of the economic.

The second reason is that it distorts our understanding of the sphere of culture. Common expressions like 'the *impact* of globalization on culture' or 'the cultural *consequences* of globalization' contain a tacit assumption that globalization is a process which somehow has its sources and its terrain of operation *outside* of culture. One major reason why it seems natural to speak of globalization's 'impact' on culture is that global market processes – particularly the distribution of iconic consumer goods – are relatively easy to understand as having a potential influence on people's cultural experience. This, indeed, is at the core of the interpretation of cultural globalization as 'cultural imperialism', 'Americanization' or 'Westernization', or as the spread of a global capitalist-consumerist monoculture (Tomlinson 1991, 1999). In all such readings 'culture' seems to be a peculiarly inert category: something that people experience or imbibe but do not themselves produce or shape. Much has been written from the semiotic-hermeneutic perspective of cultural analysis in response to this deep misconception, demonstrating the active, transformative nature of the appropriation of cultural goods (Morley 1992; Thompson 1995; Lull 2000). But despite this critique, the idea of culture as being intrinsically *constitutive* of globalization – as being a dimension which has consequences for other domains – remains relatively obscure.

To clarify this, we have to probe a little more into the peculiarly complicated and often elusive concept of culture. 'Culture is not a power, something to which social events can be causally attributed' says Clifford Geertz (1973: 14) and this is surely right to the extent that we should think of cultural processes *primarily* as oriented towards the construction of socially shared meanings. If we were to ask the stark functional question, 'what is culture *for*?', the most satisfying answer is that it is to generate *meaning* in life. The need for 'meaning' is at the deep centre of the human condition, it is the cognitive-existential equivalent of the material needs for shelter and sustenance. Indeed it may be considered more than these, since people, in certain conditions, are willing to sacrifice these other needs to their convictions about the purpose and the good ends of existence. The shared stories – the 'narratives' – by which we render our existence meaningful, then, are, as it were, *ends in themselves* for culture. And this has, quite justly, shaped the way in which culture has been typically studied: as lived experience, as representation, as text and as context.

The notion of 'causality' sits awkwardly with this conceptualization. However, this does not mean to say that culture is not *consequential*. It is certainly so in that the practices and processes of meaning construction inform, inspire and direct individual and collective actions which are *themselves* consequential. Culture is thus not only 'a context in which [events] may be meaningfully interpreted' (Geertz 1973), it is *the* primordial context in which human agency arises and takes place. Cultural signification and interpretation constantly motivate and orient people, individually and collectively, towards particular choices and actions. Actions which may seem to be fairly instrumental ones, following a logic of practical or economic necessity, are nonetheless always undertaken within that set of self-understandings, plans, hopes or aspirations which we can think of as the constitutive elements of the individual's cultural 'lifeworld'. Even the most basic instrumental actions of satisfying bodily needs are not in this sense outside of culture: in certain circumstances – slimming, eating 'disorders' such as anorexia nervosa, religious fasting, political hunger strikes – the decision to eat or to starve is a *cultural* decision.

One useful way to think about the consequentiality of culture for globalization, then, is to grasp how culturally informed 'local' actions can have globalizing consequences. The 'moment of culture' in the shopping decisions of young people on Saturday afternoons – to buy this or that brand of jeans or training shoes or mobile phone – is one of self-representation, against a background narrative of appropriate cultural style: How do I want to be perceived? What cultural images do I want to conform to or contrast with? What do I value? What do I desire? These are not banal questions, even though we may judge consumerism incapable of providing satisfying answers. But neither are they questions that remain locked within the subjectivities of human beings. The answers to them are, as it were, *performative*. Consumer activity is, in micro, constitutive of the whole complex network of global market connectivity, having consequences not only for the employment of workers in distant parts of the world but, in respect of the natural resources consumed and the industrial processes entailed in their production, for the ecological fate of the planet. To borrow a term from Anthony Giddens (1990), cultural globalization involves the increasing 'reflexivity' of modern life: the systemic integration of myriad small individual actions into the workings of the social institutions which appear autonomously to govern our lives.

This is enough of a theoretical preamble. What I have emphasized here – because it is so fundamental to understanding the agenda of globalization from a cultural perspective – is that culture is a dimension in which globalization both has its effects and *simultaneously* is generated and shaped.

But now, moving to more concrete issues, we need to ask: what sort of shape is emerging?

A GLOBAL CULTURE?

One common speculation about the globalization process is that it will lead to a single global culture. This is only a speculation, but the reason it seems possible is that we can see the ‘unifying’ effects of connectivity in other spheres – particularly in the economic sphere where the tightly integrated system of the global market provides the model. And indeed, globalization in some of its aspects does have this general unifying character. Whereas it was in the past possible to understand social and economic processes and practices as a set of local, relatively ‘independent’ phenomena, globalization makes the world in many respects, to quote Roland Robertson (1992), a ‘single place’. Obvious examples of this are the way in which nation-states are locked into a complex global capitalistic system which restricts their autonomy independently to order their economic affairs, or the now evident tendency for environmental effects of local industrial processes – for instance CFC emissions – rapidly to become global problems.

However, increasing global connectivity by no means *necessarily* implies that the world is becoming, in the widest sense, either economically or politically ‘unified’. Despite its reach, few would dare to claim that the effects of globalization currently extend in any profound way to every single person or place on the planet, and speculation on its spread must surely be tempered by the many countervailing trends towards social, political and indeed cultural *division* that we see around us. This is a point that is frequently made in the field of development studies: what used to be called the ‘Third World’ clearly does not partake of the globalized economy or of globalized communications *in the same way* as the developed world. An overarching global economic system, it is true to say, is deeply influential in determining the fate of countries in Africa. But this is a far cry from saying that Africa is part of a single, unified world of economic prosperity and social and technological development. So we have to *qualify* the idea of globalization by saying that it is an *uneven* process – with areas of concentration and density of flow and other areas of neglect or even perhaps exclusion (Massey 1994). To this extent, globalization, it seems, is not quite global!

Despite all this, there persists, at least amongst some Western critics, a tendency to imagine globalization pushing us towards an all-encompassing ‘global culture’. The most common way in which this is conceived is in the assumption that I mentioned earlier, that cultural globalization implies a form of cultural imperialism: the spread of Western capitalist – particularly American – culture to every part of the globe, and the consequent threat of a loss of distinct non-Western cultural traditions. What is feared here is the total domination of world cultures through the unopposed advance of iconic brands such as Disney, Coca-Cola, Marlboro,

Microsoft, Google, McDonald's, CNN, Nike and Starbucks. Globally marketed formulaic Hollywood movies, Western popular music genres and television formats appear to many as what the filmmaker Bernardo Bertolucci once referred to as 'a kind of totalitarianism of culture'.

Much has been written in criticism of this anxiety and I don't want either to review or to add to this particular debate here. I will simply observe that the issue is incapable of resolution if we restrict analysis to the rather superficial issue of the global distribution of cultural goods. What is at stake for cultural analysis is not the (undoubted) capacity of Western corporations to command wide markets for their products around the world, but rather, the deeper cultural implications of this capacity. We have to be careful not to confuse mere cultural goods with the *practice* of culture itself – which involves the interpretation and the appropriation of meanings in relation to such goods. Eating McDonald's hamburgers, smoking Marlboro cigarettes, drinking Coke and playing computer games may be bad for you in all sorts of ways. But they do not in themselves provide much solid evidence of a capitulation to deeper Western cultural values.

Indeed, one of the inescapable implications of the current wave of anti-Western feeling in large parts of the Muslim world is precisely the demonstration of the resilience of cultural *opposition* to (certain, not all, of) these values. Just as we have witnessed a ratcheting up, since the events of 11 September 2001 and then the invasion of Iraq, in the neo-conservative rhetoric of a self-conscious project of US cultural-political global hegemony, there has been inescapable evidence – some of it violent, bloody and destructive, but much of it peaceful – of a rejection of this project. Without being drawn too deeply into these perplexing issues, we can at least see that the vision of Western liberal-capitalist consumer culture sweeping all before it is severely chastened by this cultural opposition. What the connectivity of globalization is doing is bringing quite disparate cultures into closer contact – by no means inevitably as a 'clash of civilizations' (Huntington 1996) – but certainly involving contending definitions of what the good, the virtuous and the dignified life involves. What globalization is clearly *not* doing, however, if it is doing this, is effortlessly installing Western culture as global culture.

A different way of approaching these issues is to view contemporary globalization in the context of a much longer historical context in which societies and cultures have imagined the world as a single place, with their own culture at the centre of it. This sort of imagination has been a consistent feature of the founding narratives of cultural collectivities – particularly of faith communities – and we can learn something appropriate to the contemporary situation from a brief consideration of a couple of historical examples.

The first comes from long before the current phase of globalizing modernity, in fact from thirteenth-century Europe. It is not a conventional cultural text, or a body of ideas associated with a particular thinker. It is a much more direct representation of the world: a map.

The Ebstorf Mappa Mundi, made in c.1284, is attributed to the English cartographer Gervase of Tilbury. It is typical of early medieval European world maps, in being a mixture of eo-topography and theology. The sources of this cartographic imagination are complex, with influences from Aristotelian notions of form, and from the more directly topographical style of Roman imperial maps. The map shows

the world as round and with some recognizable features of the known physical world (that is, Europe) but without the familiar pattern of continents divided by oceans. Instead the land mass is roughly divided into three parts by rivers, and set within an encircling sea. But what is most striking is the complete domination of the representation by elements of Christian theology. Jerusalem – the Holy City – is placed at the centre, whilst the orientation of the map places the east at the top where is also depicted the Garden of Eden – scene of the Christian God's creation of mankind. The tripartite division of the map is inspired by the biblical story of the repopulation of the earth after the Deluge by Noah's three sons Ham, Shem and Japheth. All of these elements obviously reinforce Christian myths of origin, and in so doing represent the world as *unified* within the faith of Christianity. However, most striking of all is the binding force of the figure of the crucified Christ – seen in the mappa mundi only in the head, hands and feet – literally embracing the world – giving it life – from the cross.

Here, then, we find a very early, pre-modern example of an imagined theologically revealed 'globalism'. We may, of course, from our vantage point in history, smile indulgently on the rudimentary nature of the topography. Or, taking a more sophisticated perspective, we can understand it, within its historical-cultural context, as a different *order* of representation in which the sacred and the empirical are not so easily disentangled. But what we cannot mistake, given our modern relativizing sensibilities, is the entirely spurious nature of its universal pretensions. This is not *the world*, but *a world*: the imagined world of 'Christendom'.

The interesting point, however, is that this universalizing discourse has by no means disappeared with the sophistications of cultural modernity. Just as the medieval cartographer ignored (or in some cases, more precisely, was ignorant of) the rival claims of the non-Christian world – of the Islamic Ummah, of Buddhism or Confucianism for instance – so, many contemporary universalizing narratives seem to work by ignoring or, worse, denigrating cultural difference.

Some believe that this is peculiarly emphasized within the tradition of Christianity. Slavoj Žižek for instance argues:

In other 'particularistic' religions (and even in Islam, in spite of its global expansionism), there is at least a place for others, they are tolerated, even if they are condescendingly looked upon. The Christian motto, 'all men are brothers', however, means also that, 'Those who are not my brothers are not men'. Christians usually praise themselves for overcoming the Jewish exclusivist notion of the Chosen People and encompassing all of humanity – the catch here is that, in their very insistence that they are the 'Chosen People' with the privileged direct link to God, Jews accept the humanity of the other people who celebrate their false gods, while Christian universalism tendentially excludes non-believers from the very universality of mankind. (Žižek 2001: 144)

Though Žižek may have a point here – at least at the level of Christian dogma – it would be foolish, of course, to suppose that the *practice* of all Christians is so exclusive. For on the liberal wing of Christian ecumenism there are clearly deep inclusivist sensibilities which shade into forms of internationalism sometimes barely distinguishable from secular humanism in their implicit terms of membership. Moreover, as Terry Eagleton reminds us, many other cultures, besides Christian

ones, have denied the status of 'human beings' to strangers and so, 'One should not be ethnocentric about ethnocentricity' (Eagleton 2000: 57).

But the point I want to press is that this tendency towards unwarranted universalizing – what we might call particular cultures *masquerading* as universal ones – is not restricted either to religious worldviews or to 'pre-modern' cultures, but can be seen at the core of European Enlightenment rationality. From this source, it preserves the imagined projection of 'our world' into 'the world' as a core feature of Western cultural modernity. This privileging of the European cultural experience – along with its particular version of rationality and its cultural and political values – can be seen in 'cosmopolitan' thinkers from Kant onwards. It is Kant, indeed, who in his famous seminal text on cosmopolitanism not only looks back for his model to classical Greece and Rome, but forwards, speculatively, to a time when the continent of Europe, 'will probably legislate . . . for all the others' (Kant (1784) 'The idea of a universal history from a cosmopolitan point of view' – quoted in Derrida 2002: 7). But for my second example of a global imagination, I want to take a European thinker who, though taking something from the Kantian tradition, is arguably a more influential cosmopolitan and one closer, culturally, to our times.

Karl Marx's depiction of a future communist society provides what is perhaps the most vivid imagination of a global culture to be found in either nineteenth- or twentieth-century social thought. In the *Communist Manifesto* Marx and Engels present a bold vision of a future world in which the divisions of nations have disappeared, along with all other 'local' attachments, including those of religious belief. Communist society is a world with a universal language, a world literature and integrated cosmopolitan cultural tastes. In fact, Marx and Engels write in a way that seems to anticipate some defining features of the current globalization process:

In the place of the old wants satisfied by the productions of the country, we find new wants, requiring for their satisfaction the products of distant lands and climes. In the place of the old local and national seclusion and self-sufficiency we have intercourse in every direction, universal interdependence of nations. . . . The intellectual creations of individual nations become common property. National one-sidedness and narrow-mindedness become more and more impossible and from the numerous national and local literatures there arises a world literature. (Marx and Engels 1969: 52–3)

But Marx combines this vision with a deeply Eurocentric attitude to other cultures. He welcomes the way in which the bourgeois era is sweeping away pre-modern 'civilizations', preparing the way for the coming socialist revolution and the communist era which, he insists, 'can only have a "world-historical" existence'. To achieve this radically cosmopolitan end, Marx is quite happy to see the destruction of non-European cultures. The *Manifesto* continues:

The bourgeoisie, by the rapid improvement of all instruments of production, by the immensely facilitated means of communication, draws all, even the most barbarian, nations into civilization. The cheap prices of its commodities are the heavy artillery with which it batters down all Chinese walls, with which it forces the barbarians' intensely obstinate hatred of foreigners to capitulate. (1969: 53)

For the fact is that Marx was a convinced internationalist who despised national sentiments as reactionary forces in all societies, set against the cosmopolitan interests of the proletariat – the true and only ‘workers of the world’. But, for all his many progressive views and the brilliance and percipience of his political-economy, his view of culture was firmly rooted in a European tradition which – following Kant, Hegel and others – unquestioningly took its *own* experience as the pattern for universal experience. Indeed, it might be argued that it was this Eurocentric cast of Marx’s thought which led him to underestimate the enduring power and significance of ethnic and religious attachments (or their transformation into nationalism) in modernity. Marx’s universalizing modernism was, in a curious way, as blind to cultural difference as the universalizing Christianity of the medieval mapmaker.

Marx’s views, formed in the mid-nineteenth century, a similarly turbulent and dynamic period of global capitalist expansion to our own, remain relevant today – though not in the form that he might have imagined. For what he saw as an ultimately benign aspect of the progress of transnational capitalism – which he argues ‘must nestle everywhere, settle everywhere, establish connections everywhere’ – as an agent of historical change, appears to today’s cultural critics as precisely the reverse. By contrast with contemporary neo-Marxists, who, in the main, tend towards the pessimistic, Marx appears as cheerfully optimistic about the prospects for globality – and unabashed in his Eurocentrism.

True, such sentiments could scarcely flourish in today’s liberal intellectual culture, sharply attuned as it is to the claims of cultural difference. But still we can take a lesson from Marx’s example, and it is that the ethnocentric tendency towards universalizing projections of a global culture can coexist with otherwise rational progressive humanistic visions. This certainly remains true today: and it is there not just in the rhetoric of national political leaders, but in the constituencies to which this rhetoric appeals. To take one’s own culture as the ‘obvious’ model for the one, true, enlightened, rational and good is as common as it is understandable. Relativizing this model requires much more difficult acts of hermeneutic distancing and of intellectual and affective imagination.

But this is precisely what we need to do if we are to avoid the sort of violent contestation of worldviews that looks so threatening in our present world. Making cosmopolitanism – in the rather simple, literal sense of ‘world citizenship’ – work in a way that does not impose any *one* particular, culturally inflected model is perhaps the most immediate cultural challenge that globalization faces us with. I will return to this issue in the last part of this chapter. But, before that, we can turn to another aspect of globalization – which might just offer a little more cause for optimism in the face of this challenge.

DETERRITORIALIZATION

One clear implication of the discussion in the previous section is that both utopian and dystopian speculations about a single integrated global culture are not only generally ethnocentric in their origins, they are – in part because of this – rather poor predictions of actual cultural development. But there is another, more promising, way of approaching cultural globalization. This is not via the macro analysis

of 'globality', but precisely in the opposite way, by understanding the effects of globalization as they are felt within particular *localities*.

The vast majority of us live local lives, but globalization is rapidly changing our experience of this 'locality' and one way of grasping this change is in the idea of 'deterritorialization'. As Nestor García Canclini describes it, the idea of deterritorialization implies 'the loss of the "natural" relation of culture to geographical and social territories' (García Canclini 1995: 229). Deterritorialization, then, means that the significance of the geographical location of a culture – not only the physical, environmental and climatic location, but all the self-definitions, ethnic boundaries and delimiting practices that have accrued around this – is eroding. No longer is culture so 'tied' to the constraints of local circumstances.

In fact the idea of deterritorialization has fairly radical theoretical implications for traditional ways of understanding culture. Culture has long held connotations tying it to the idea of a fixed locality. The idea of 'a culture' implicitly connects meaning construction with particularity and location: with 'territory'. Indeed, in the mainstream sociological treatment of culture, particularly in the functionalist tradition where collective meaning construction is seen largely as serving the purposes of social integration, there has been a tacit assumption that culture is a spatially bounded entity, somehow paralleling the bounded, integrated entity of the 'society' (Mann 1986). But the complex connectivity of globalization threatens to undermine such conceptualizations, not only because the multiform *penetration* of localities disrupts this binding of meanings to place, but also because it challenges the rather insular thinking through which culture and fixity of location are originally paired.

If globalization, in its rawest description, is the spread of complex social-economic connections across distance, then deterritorialization refers to the *reach* of this connectivity into the localities in which everyday life is conducted and experienced. This is at the same time a perplexing and disruptive, and an exhilarating and empowering phenomenon, involving the simultaneous penetration of our local worlds by distant forces, and the dislodging of everyday meanings from their 'anchors' in the local environment.

It may well be that, in the long run, this 'weakening' of the traditional ties between cultural experience and geographical territory will prove to be the most far-reaching effect of cultural globalization. But we should be clear about precisely what this entails. Deterritorialization is *not* simply the *loss* of the experience of a local culture: it is not as though localities, and the particularities, nuances and differences they generate, suddenly and entirely disappear. Localities, on the contrary, thrive in globalization – this is the source of that often noted paradox that globalization tends to produce intensities in ethnic identification – even to the point of the violent contesting of local territory along ethnic lines (Kaldor 1999). In less extreme terms, a moment's thought about the places we live in reminds us that, despite the forces of globalization, they all retain a high degree of cultural distinctiveness. This applies not only to remote and 'exotic' corners and backwaters of the world, untouched by the flows of global modernity, but to capital cities and great metropolitan centres – the most concentrated locations of global connectivity. London clearly has its own cultural 'feel' which is quite different from Madrid, New York, Tokyo or Beijing.

So what is different? The difference that deterritorialization makes is that the culture produced by locality is no longer – as it may well have been in the past – the single most important factor in our lived reality. Deterritorialization refers to the integration of *distant* events, processes and relationships into our everyday lives and it is this *added* dimension of experience that accounts for the attenuation of the hold that local particularities have on modern cultures.

This ‘deterritorializing’ aspect of globalization is felt in very ordinary everyday practices: as we push our trolleys around the aisles of ‘global foods’ in local supermarkets; as we choose between eating in Italian, Mexican, Thai, Indian or Japanese restaurants; as we settle down in our living rooms to watch an American soap opera or the news coverage of a distant political event; as we casually phone friends on other continents, aware of their ‘distance’ only in terms of a time difference; as we routinely log on to *Google* for information rather than walking down to the local public library. These activities are now so taken-for-granted in the affluent, developed parts of the world, that they seem almost too trivial to consider as signalling deep cultural transformations. Yet they do. It is through such changes that globalization reaches deep into our individual cultural ‘worlds’, the implicit sense we all have of our relevant environment, our understanding of what *counts* as home and abroad, our horizon of cultural and moral relevance, even our sense of cultural and national identity (Tomlinson 1999: 113f; 2003).

The phenomenon of deterritorialization arises from a complex set of economic, political and technological factors and in fact, like globalization itself, it is not a phenomenon which can usefully be tied down to one dimension of analysis. But, having said this, there is one factor which *is* worth singling out for closer scrutiny, since it opens out on to areas of connectivity that are historically unprecedented and which may justifiably be said to define the tenor of our times. This is our increasing routine dependence on electronic media and communications technologies and systems.

What we can call the ‘telemediatization’ of culture is a key distinction in twenty-first century life. Often this distinction is grasped as a peculiar form of *mobility* that does not involve actual physical movement. Typically, the use of the Internet, and even to some degree of television, is described as a form of ‘virtual travel’ and popular expressions often employ metaphors of mobility (surfing, channel hopping, navigating and so on). Whilst there is some force in these metaphors, it seems to me more useful to think of telemediatization as a historically novel form in which experience is made ‘present’ to human beings: as, indeed, a distinctive *mode* of deterritorialization. Telemediatized practices – watching television or typing, scrolling, clicking and browsing at the computer screen or talking, texting or sending and receiving pictures on a mobile phone – should be regarded as unique modes of cultural activity and perception. Although they are now so much a taken-for-granted aspect of everyday life in developed societies we should remember that none of these activities and experiences have any counterpart beyond the last few decades of world history. Our use of media and communications technologies thus helps to define what it is to exist as a social being in the modern world.

It seems to me, then, that one of the main challenges of global cultural analysis is to come to terms with the way in which telemediatization is shaping our lives – and, indeed, our values. Just to pick out one significant theme, there is now a

widespread assumption that the *speed* of electronic communication is an undisputed good – and that modern social life as it were, has its inevitable ‘pace’ set by this technology. This is not, of course, an idea that has stolen upon us all at once: we can trace a trajectory of increasing acceleration in media technologies, from the telegraph through the telephone and radio and television broadcasting systems, up to the convergences between mobile phones, the Internet and a complex network of databases, tracking and delivery systems which is on the near technological horizon. But the cultural assumption that runs through these technological developments is in fact relatively historically novel: it is that communication is to be valued not only in terms of clarity, intelligibility, truthfulness and improved mutuality of understanding: it is to be valued, increasingly, in terms of *speed* of delivery.

If we add to these technological developments innovations in media institutions themselves – for instance 24-hour television, online news services, multimedia delivery systems via domestic broadband provision – there emerges a sense of what we could call the increasing ‘immediacy’ of modern global culture. The most direct impact of this is probably felt in changes in consumption practices (television or online shopping), entertainment (the downloading and retrieval of music via MP3 devices like the, now almost culturally iconic, *iPod*) or simply the possibility of immediate access to other people (mobile phone conversation or ‘texting’) – the last of which may, without exaggeration, be thought of as a defining feature of contemporary youth culture. And there are wider implications: for example in the political process, where the discourse of politicians is increasingly finely tuned to the demands of a media demanding instant responses on all issues, where political parties during elections even issue ‘pre-emptive’ policy statements and where global financial markets instantly react to political events – or merely to nuances in the words of political leaders.

But the larger cultural question – as yet scarcely addressed – is what all this speed and ‘instant access’ means in the longer term for our emotions, our social relations and our cultural values, for example, the value of patience. I do not want to suggest that global ‘immediacy’ will necessarily prove to be bad for us. But it is undoubtedly a dimension of cultural power in itself, to be reckoned alongside the power of the marketplace, or of political ideologies. And it is producing a definite shift in the way in which people make sense of the world. The agenda of global cultural analysis, then, certainly includes understanding the ‘runaway’ speed of modern media technologies and systems – and probably extends to the devising of viable strategies for their regulation.

But returning to the general theme of deterritorialization, I want to suggest, as I hinted at earlier, that there is at least the germ of optimism in this process for the broader cultural-political challenges that global connectivity poses. Deterritorialization not only disturbs and transforms local experience, it potentially offers people wider cultural horizons. In various ways – through increased travel and mobility, the use of new communications technologies and the experience of a globalized media – people effortlessly integrate local and ‘global’ cultural data in their consciousness. Thus, what happens in distant parts of the world, though still perhaps not so vivid as events in our neighbourhood, nonetheless has an increasing significance in our lives – particularly since it may have readily traceable consequences for us. The positive potential of deterritorialization, then, is that, in changing our

experience of local life, it may promote a new sensibility of cultural openness, human mutuality and global ethical responsibility. In the final part of this chapter, I shall develop these thoughts via a brief consideration of the fate of cultural identity in a globalizing world.

COSMOPOLITANISM AND CULTURAL IDENTITY

As I suggested in discussion of the prospects for a global culture, the idea of a progressive, cosmopolitan cultural politics deserves to be taken seriously. This does not necessarily mean endorsing grand projects for 'global governance'; rather it means trying to clarify, and ultimately to reconcile, the attachments and the values of cultural difference with those of an emergent wider global-human 'community'. This is a dilemma. On the one hand there are the attractions of what we might think of as a 'benign' form of universalism, preserving some key ideas of human mutuality and underlying the broad discourse of human rights and the hope of wider horizons of global solidarity. But on the other, the equally attractive principles of respect for the integrity of local context and practices, cultural autonomy, cultural identity and 'sovereignty'. At the heart of the cultural-political problems posed by contemporary globalization, lies what Amanda Anderson (1998) has described as the 'divided legacies of modernity': two sets of strong rational principles pulling in different directions. Universal human rights or cultural difference? We don't really know which flag to stand beside because in most cases there seem good reasons to stand beside both (Tomlinson 2002; Walzer 1994).

I do not suppose there is any easy solution to this dilemma, but in the short space available I want to suggest that we may get some way along the road by addressing another rather vexed issue in cultural politics, that is, the question of the formation of 'cultural identity'.

Considered formally, rather than psychologically, 'identities' are aspects of the differentiating, institutionalizing and socially regulating nature of modern life. Modernity, indeed, might be considered, at a level of abstraction above that of a determinant set of social institutions (capitalism, technology and industrialism, urbanism, the nation-state system) as the very tendency to form institutions and to generate regulators of social-economic-cultural behaviour. Considered in this way, cultural identities are specifically *modern* entities – ways of categorizing, organizing and regulating the cultural practices, representations and imaginings by which we grasp our existential condition, our personal relations and our attachment to a place or a community.

This essentially modern, 'regulatory' category of cultural identity, then, consists in self and communal definitions based around specific, usually politically inflected, differentiations: gender, sexuality, class, religion, race and ethnicity, nationality. Some of these differentiations of course existed before the coming of modernity, some – like nationality – are more or less modern imaginings. But the relevance of modernity here is not so much in the nature and substance – the contents – of identifications, as in the fact they are formally and publicly recognized, named and regulated. Modern societies orchestrate existential experience according to tacit but nonetheless well-policed boundaries. We 'live' our gender, our sexuality, our

nationality and so forth within institutional regimes of discursively organized belongings. What could be much more amorphous, contingent, particular and tacit senses of belonging become structured into an array – a portfolio – of identities, each with implications for our material and psychological well-being, each, thus, with its own ‘politics’. As globalization distributes the institutional features of modernity across all cultures, it therefore generates these institutionalized forms of cultural belonging – in some cases where they have not before played any role in cultural life.

One rather interesting interpretation of the impact of globalization to flow from this is that, far from destroying it – as many suppose – globalization has been perhaps the most significant force in *creating and proliferating* cultural identity (Tomlinson 2003). Those who regard globalization as a *threat* to cultural identity tend to imagine identity quite differently. Rather than noticing its institutional features, they tend to see identity as something like an existential ‘possession’, an inheritance, a benefit of traditional long dwelling, of continuity with the past. Identity, according to this common view, is more than just a description of the experience of cultural belonging, it is a sort of collective treasure of local communities. Moreover, whilst long ensuring the culturally sustaining connections between geographical place and human experience, identity, according to this view, is suddenly discovered to be fragile, in need of protection and preservation, a treasure that can be lost. This is the story which implicates globalization – and specifically deterritorialization – in the destruction of local identities.

However, the crucial mistake of those who regard globalization as a *threat* to cultural identity is to confuse this Western-modern form of cultural imagination with a universal of human experience. All cultures construct meaning via practices of collective symbolization: this is probably as close to a cultural universal as we can get. But by no means all historical cultures have ‘constructed’ identity in the regulated institutional forms that are now dominant in the modern West (Morley 2000).

Let us now try to connect these thoughts about the institutionalization of identity with the issue of cosmopolitanism. The way we can do this is to understand the cosmopolitan disposition – the sympathy with a globally encompassing humanism and with rights and obligations belonging to this – as belonging to a specific identity position.

Whatever the composition, or the historical/territorial origins of the discourse of human rights – a discourse *encompassing* for the most part, rather than contesting other forms of universalism – it owes most to its modern institutional form. ‘Humanity’ – in its juridical form of an owner of rights or a victim of persecution or exploitation – is, in effect, a specific modern identity position which is universal by definition, but which remains compatible with a huge range of cultural variation, by dint of its precise context of invocation. Human rights can be invoked to defend cultural difference in just the same way that they can be used to argue for universal standards of justice, or equality of provision in healthcare, education and so forth.

To be, without contradiction, ‘human’ in its rich pluralist acceptance of preserving cultural difference, and ‘human’ in juridical-universalizing terms, is a trick brought off precisely by the institutionalized framing of *repertoires* of identity

typical of modernity. The key here is the pluralism of identity positions. In the midst of the proliferation of localisms and sharpened identity discriminations, globalization also – formally, adroitly and without any recourse to particular cultural traditions – generates a flexible category of cosmopolitan belonging.

But how does this understanding help with the dilemma of whether to endorse universalism or the politics of difference? Well let's not pretend that it magics away all of the conceptual tensions, or the real political problems around putative regimes of global governance predicated on universal human rights. What we put inside the box labelled 'human rights' will still be a matter of contention. However, thinking about these issues in terms of identity positions does, perhaps, soften some of the starker intractabilities. Just as it is possible, without contradiction, to hold a repertoire of identities – to be at the same time female, Chinese, a Beijinger, a political dissident, a patriot, a Buddhist and an admirer of Western liberalism – so it is possible to hold rights which are, as it were, *transferable* across different contexts. To this extent, the appeal to human universalism is itself dependent on context: it can be invoked in situations where more particular local communal attachments can be reasonably judged to be repressive. But it does not need to be considered as the card which trumps all 'lesser' rights and duties. Identities we know are constructs not possessions. Despite the historical tendency for cultures and nations to claim universality as their possession, the appeal to the universal can perhaps be made to work in a cosmopolitan world order as a *construct*: as one way, amongst others, of understanding our human condition and of relating in dialogue with others. What is clear, finally, is that, faced with a future world of what Clifford Geertz has called 'pressed-together dissimilarities variously arranged, rather than all-of-a-piece nation-states grouped into blocs and superblocs' (Geertz 2000: 226), we urgently need to come up with much more nimble and flexible cultural concepts than we so far possess.

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